

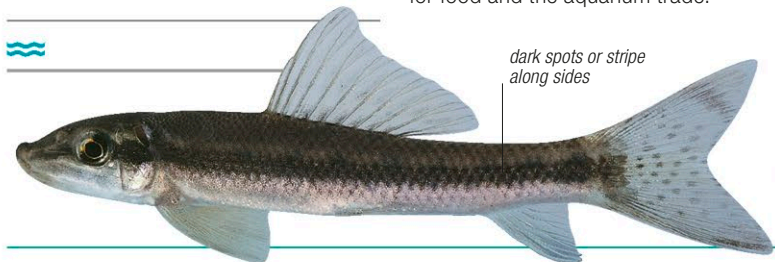
Gyrinocheilus aymonieri

Siamese algae-eater



Length 11 in (28 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location S.E. Asia



Found on solid surfaces at the bottom of flowing water, this slender fish has a modified mouth and lips that it uses to attach itself to rocks and plants, scraping plant material from them. It is golden green above and silvery below, and has a large dorsal fin with 9 branched fin rays. The Siamese algae-eater is commercially exploited for food and the aquarium trade.

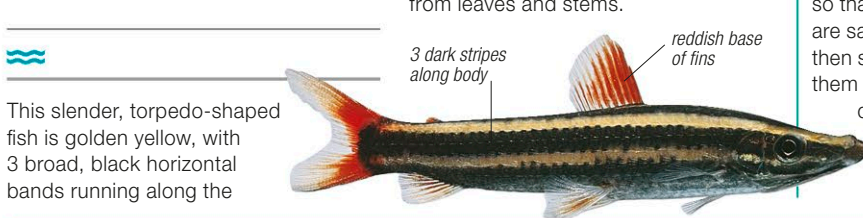
Anostomus anostomus

Striped headstander



Length 6½ in (16 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America



This slender, torpedo-shaped fish is golden yellow, with 3 broad, black horizontal bands running along the

body, from the snout to the tail fin. The slender head has an upturned snout, and all fins have reddish bases. This fish gets its name from its habit of swimming head-down, at an oblique angle to the beds of rivers and streams. It swims in small schools (containing up to 40 individuals), often remaining motionless among vegetation. Its upturned mouth enables it to feed from leaves and stems.

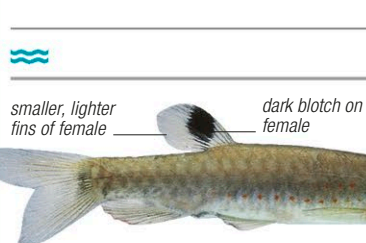
Copella arnoldi

Splash tetra



Length 1½ in (4 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America



Also called the jumping characin, this finger-sized fish has a slender, creamy yellow body, with a black stripe on the head and through the eye. It belongs to a group of freshwater species, the lebiasinids (pencilfish), often kept in aquariums. This particular species gets its name from its distinctive reproductive behavior. The female lays her eggs on the underside of overhanging leaves, so that when the water level drops, they are safe from most predators. The male then splashes them with water to keep them alive and the young fishes drop back into the water after they have hatched. Splash tetras feed on worms, insect larvae, and crustaceans.

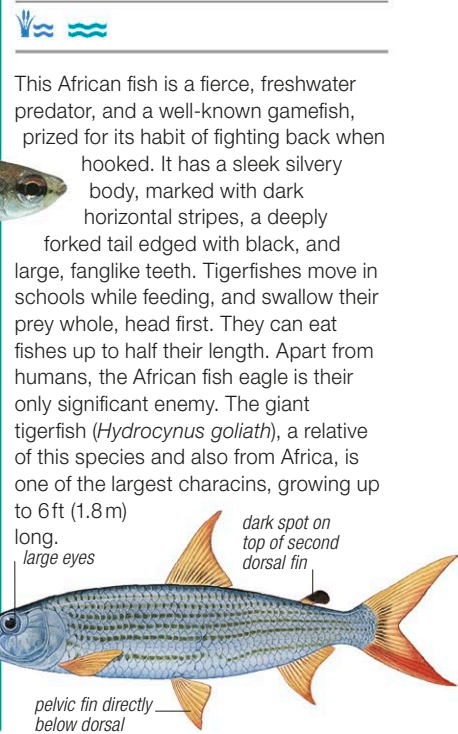
Hydrocynus vittatus

Tigerfish



Length 3¼ ft (1 m)
Weight 40 lb (Up to 18 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location Africa



This African fish is a fierce, freshwater predator, and a well-known gamefish, prized for its habit of fighting back when hooked. It has a sleek silvery body, marked with dark horizontal stripes, a deeply forked tail edged with black, and large, fanglike teeth. Tigerfishes move in schools while feeding, and swallow their prey whole, head first. They can eat fishes up to half their length. Apart from humans, the African fish eagle is their only significant enemy. The giant tigerfish (*Hydrocynus goliath*), a relative of this species and also from Africa, is one of the largest characins, growing up to 6 ft (1.8 m).

Astyanax mexicanus

Mexican tetra



Length 4¾ in (12 cm)
Weight Not recorded
Sex Male/Female
Status Least concern

Location S. Central USA to Mexico



Found in springs, creeks, and small rivers, the Mexican tetra typically has a silvery body with red and yellow fins. This fish is of interest to biologists because a variant of the species is found in caves. The subterranean form, called blind cave characin (pictured right), looks very different, with its reduced pigmentation and nonfunctioning eyes covered by skin. Like other cave-dwelling fishes, it finds food by

using its pressure-sensing lateral line and its keen sense of smell. Despite the differences

in color and eye development, the 2 forms of Mexican tetra are similar at a genetic level, and can interbreed.

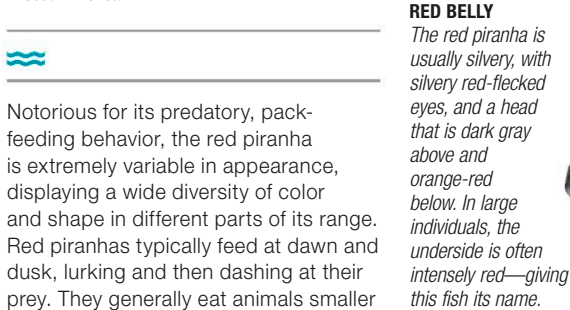
Pygocentrus nattereri

Red piranha



Length Up to 20 in (50 cm)
Weight Up to 8¼ lb (3.9 kg)
Sex Male/Female
Status Not evaluated

Location N., C., and E. South America



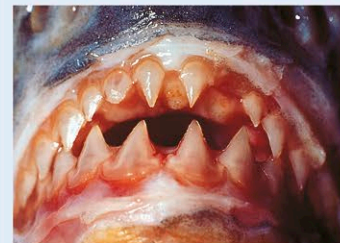
than themselves, such as insects, aquatic invertebrates, or other fishes, and will also feed on seeds and fruit. However, given an opportunity, these extremely aggressive, voracious predators can kill much larger prey by hunting as a group, feeding in a frenzied rush reminiscent of the behavior of some sharks. These mass attacks can

kill animals as large as capybaras and horses, and have also resulted in some human deaths. During the breeding season, female red piranhas lay up to 1,000 relatively large eggs, and attach them to the roots of trees trailing in the water. Both parents, particularly the male, guard the eggs until they hatch, which takes about 9–10 days.

RED BELLY

The red piranha is usually silvery, with silvery red-flecked eyes, and a head that is dark gray above and orange-red below. In large individuals, the underside is often intensely red—giving this fish its name.

SLICING TEETH



Red piranhas have small but sharp, triangular teeth set in powerful jaws. The teeth interlock when the fish's mouth is closed, enabling it to slice off chunks of flesh. The blunt snout and underslung lower jaw also help it to attack, allowing it to bite with unusual force.